everyone watching and evaluating the Reserve Bank would say: ‘The RBI is a role model for the kind of knowledge and ethical institution that a central bank should be.’

There was a lunch that afternoon to bid me farewell and welcome Governor Rajan. Gathered there were the directors on the board of the Reserve Bank, serving senior management and retired senior officers of the Reserve Bank, CEOs of banks and financial Institutions, other financial sector regulators—about 200 in all. There was the expected round of speeches—nostalgic, emotional and touching.

I kept my own remarks deliberately quite light-hearted. I told the gathering that there are many things I will miss about being governor, but most of all I will miss being important. Once I step down, I will enjoy the freedom to open my mouth without the pressure of having to say something profound every time I spoke, that I look forward to spending time with my ninety-plus-year-old mother-in-law and that I will freak out on going to a matinee show of *Chennai Express*. I gave some advice to Raghu. He could, I told him, comfortably delegate to his senior staff less important decisions like interest-rate changes and to whom to issue bank licences, but that he ought to retain with himself important decisions like the menu for lunches to be hosted by the governor, gifts to be given to visiting dignitaries and seating arrangements at meetings.

At a brief ceremony at three that afternoon, I signed off and Governor Rajan signed on. Minutes later, I walked out of the office, went down the elevator—with hundreds of Reserve Bank staff present on the ground floor to see me off, and cameras of assembled press photographers clicking away—got into the car and drove away into life after the Reserve Bank.

Summing Up

In the five years that I was governor, I ran into thousands of strangers who recognized me, complimented me and were generous in their appreciation of what I was doing at the Reserve Bank. Every such meeting was a heart-warming experience as their compliments were so genuine. The most